to represent, the Bolsheviks had done themselves great harm in the East by the bad impression they had given. However, 'If it was merely a plan to collect together a heterogeneous mass of Asiatic undesirables with a view to enlisting them as agents and agitators, then the Bolsheviks appear to have been most successful.'[185] The gathering together of a large number of anti-British malcontents was a worry in itself for Britain. As one Tiflis newspaper pointed out, at the Congress the representatives of the revolutionary and nationalists movements 'will have facilities for meeting and discussing mutual measures and co-operation. If they do this, then the Conference will serve as the first step towards a union of the forces of the Eastern peoples...'[186] The last thing the British government needed was for the revolutionary movements in Central and southern Asia to combine and organise themselves. Indeed, one of the few practical results of the Congress was the creation of a Council of Propaganda and Action in the East.[187] Two months after Baku, a school would also be set up in Tashkent under the direction of M.N. Roy with the specific aim of training Indian and Asian malcontents in Communist revolutionary theory (its first students were a handful of Muhajirun who had not returned to India with the others).[188]

The crucial result of the Baku Congress then, was that it served to disturb the British government (and would contribute to the seeking of an accord with the Bolshevik regime in 1921). Furthermore, the Congress was an apt summary of the relationship between Bolshevism and the pan-Islamist and nationalist movements in Asia in the post-war period. In true Great Game style, it was an event of all show and little substance, just as the relationship between these groups did not go much deeper than a mutual anti-British fervour (not only was this the First Congress of the Peoples of the East, it was also the last). For the British government, however, any level of collaboration between these movements was enough to make it uncomfortable. Montagu summarised the situation when he wrote to Chelmsford in September 1920:

What does alarm me is that up till now it has always seemed to me that extremism in India has really been either anti-British or national. It seems to